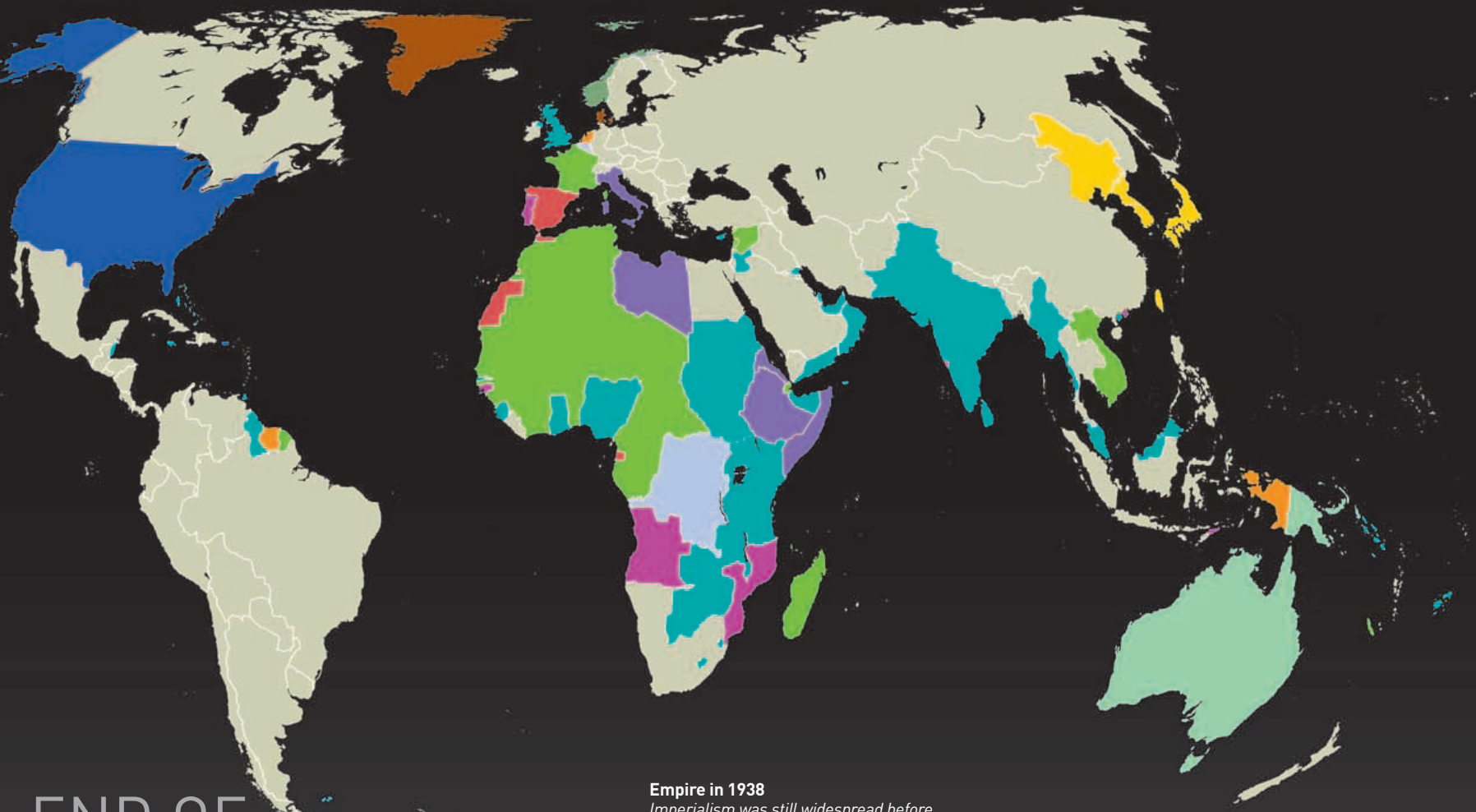




END OF EMPIRE

Empire in 1938

Imperialism was still widespread before World War II. The largest foreign-held territories were in Africa, a product of the "Scramble for Africa" in the 19th century. France and Britain were the leading colonial powers.

KEY

- ◆ United Kingdom and possessions
- France and possessions
- Denmark and possessions

COLONIAL DOMINATION CRUMBLES AS INDEPENDENCE MOVEMENTS GROW

Up until World War II, empires belonging to Britain, France, Belgium, Portugal, and the Netherlands stretched back centuries. At the end of the war, the political landscape had changed significantly, and there was mounting opposition and challenge to imperial rule. In the modern world, all that is left of the European empires is a sprinkling of islands.

By 1945 the empires of Italy, Germany, and Japan had collapsed. The British Empire emerged from the war relatively unscathed, but it was the British who made the first move to end colonialism when they granted India independence in 1947. However, change was slow. In the mid-1950s, the globe was still circled by British possessions.

Despite a widespread belief that imperialist nations had a responsibility to protect their people from Communism, many were crippled by postwar austerity and, increasingly, discontent arose among their populations. Nationalist movements flourished, supported by Soviet Russia, and encouraged by the US. This clash of ideologies complicated the transition to independence; civil war often filled the vacuum.

The last throw of the imperial dice for France and Britain came with the Suez crisis in 1956. The French were being defeated in Indo-China and were engaged in a brutal civil war in Algeria, while Britain was trying to put down rebellions in Cyprus, Kenya, and Malaya. When Egyptian president Nasser nationalized the Suez Canal, it was a further blow to British imperial powers. British and French troops invaded, but were forced into a humiliating climbdown (see 1956). The dismantling of colonies in Africa followed: France had to give up Algeria, and Belgium the Congo. But the wealth of their past rulers was never inherited by the new nations, and many former colonies struggled with foreign intervention, corruption, and poverty.

MODERN OVERSEAS TERRITORIES

Overseas territories are countries that often have a degree of autonomy, but do not possess full political independence or sovereignty as a state. Many colonies fought for self-rule after World War II, but several of them rejected independence. Some overseas territories, for example, are too small and lack the resources to survive as viable independent countries. Others, such as French Guiana in the Caribbean, which is ruled by France, and the Falkland Islands in the South Atlantic, which are ruled by Britain, are of special strategic or economic importance to the states that control them, so not easily let go.

AUSTRALIA

Ashmore and Cartier Islands
 Heard Island and the McDonald Islands
 Christmas Island
 Coral Sea Islands
 Cocos (Keeling) Islands
 Norfolk Island